from maintaining a modern, effective military, it has left the issue of the legitimacy of Japan's military and security policies in limbo. The fact that the American alliance guarantee helped avoid addressing the inconsistency head-on only led to a hardening of opinion on both sides of the domestic debate, with neither having to consider the real-world effect of either maintaining or abandoning Article 9.

Now Abe has forced the issue, at least partway, by proposing that the constitution be amended by 2020 to explicitly acknowledge the status of the Self-Defense Forces. Shying away from dropping the renunciation of war as a means of state policy, Abe wants to normalize the idea of the military as a fundamental sovereign right. That such a move would be largely symbolic does not detract from its importance in making Japan a "normal" country in conservative eyes. Even so, Abe well understands how controversial, not to mention politically fraught, any change would be, and has urged the country to "hold fast to the idea of pacifism."[27] Polls taken in the days after his May 2017 announcement showed that a slim plurality of voters wanted to keep Article 9 unchanged, while even more expressed pride in the country's pacifist tradition, and others showed a minority approving of Abe's plans to acknowledge the SDF in the constitution.[28]

Even if Abe is successful in revising the constitution, both Japanese political culture and public opinion will continue to place limits on Tokyo's global engagement and security policies. Adventurism of the kind that marks Chinese expansion in the South China Sea, Russia's annexation of the Crimea, or America's various battles around the globe is almost inconceivable for the foreseeable future. Moreover, absent a true crisis of confidence in the US-Japan alliance, it is highly unlikely to impossible that Tokyo would pursue an indigenous nuclear weapons capability in the near term. The country is even unlikely to develop offensive strike capabilities such as ballistic missiles, despite the fact that its air and naval forces are increasingly able to project limited amounts of power outside the home islands. Nor is there any real prospect of the remaining restrictions on the deployment of Japanese forces abroad being lifted, especially for combat roles.